Expressing purpose: to, in order to, so that

Goal: To express the purpose of an action or an invention with to, in order to and so that, choosing between an infinitive and a clause.

The idea in two lines: Purpose answers "Why?" or "What for?". To and in order to are followed by a verb; so that is followed by a clause (subject + modal + verb).

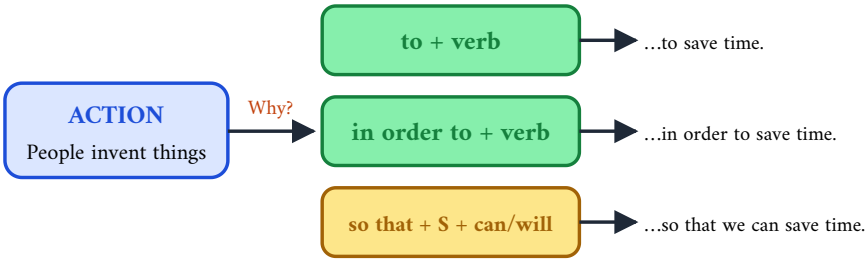


Figure 1: Three ways to express the same purpose; only so that needs a subject and a modal.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Purpose** is the reason or aim of an action: the thing we want to achieve. "Fleming studied bacteria to find new medicines."
2. **to + base verb** is the shortest and most common form: "She went to the lab to check the results."
3. **in order to + base verb** means the same but is more formal: "Scientists repeat experiments in order to confirm their results."
4. **so as to + base verb** is a third formal form with the same meaning.
5. **so that + subject + modal** introduces a clause: present ideas take can / will; past ideas take could / would. "He wrote notes so that other researchers could follow his work."
6. **Negative purpose:** in order not to / so as not to + verb; so that + subject + will not / would not. Do not write "to not".
7. **Different subjects:** when the doer and the beneficiary are different, so that is the natural choice: "The teacher explains slowly so that the pupils understand."

🟢 Examples

1. Join with "in order to": "Doctors wash their hands. They want to avoid infections." **Answer:** Doctors wash their hands in order to avoid infections. **Explanation:** same subject, so an infinitive is enough; "they want" disappears.
2. Join with "so that": "Bell invented the telephone. People could talk over long distances." **Answer:** Bell invented the telephone so that people could talk over long distances. **Explanation:** different subjects (Bell / people) and a past context, so could is used.
3. Rewrite: "We recycle paper so that we do not cut more trees." **Answer:** We recycle paper in order not to cut more trees. **Explanation:** same subject, negative purpose, so in order not to + verb.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing "for + verb" ("for to learn", "for learning") instead of **to learn** when expressing purpose.
- Putting a subject after to or in order to: "in order to people communicate".
- Forgetting the modal after **so that**: "so that people talk" is weaker than "so that people can talk".
- Mixing tenses: present main clause + could, or past main clause + can.

🟡 Quick review

- to / in order to / so as to + base verb.
- so that + subject + can / will (present) or could / would (past).
- Negative: in order not to, so as not to, so that … not.
- Same subject = infinitive; different subjects = so that.
- Purpose answers "Why?", not "How?".

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